1 Evidence Lab

Footprints and mystery powder · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 1**

11 min: 1 explain / 8 do / 2 hand over and reset | Medium energy | Arrive 1:05

SAY

"Every footprint tells a story. Measure twice. Then let's find out what that powder is."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5 (jobs at right). Rulers 1 and 2 measure the footprint under the sheet protector in cm and agree on **one** number.
2. Reveal the shoe-size chart. 26 cm = size 9. The chart reader writes it in the case file.
3. Powder test: one cup of vinegar on the tray, three labeled powders beside it. The chemist drops a spoonful of each into the vinegar, one at a time. Flour: nothing. Powdered sugar: nothing. Baking soda: erupts.
4. The evidence tech drops the EVIDENCE powder into the same cup. It erupts. "The thief left this at the scene. It's baking soda. Station 2 has five lumps of it, and now you know how to open them." (Squad 2 has already been there: "Recognize it? That's what the ghosts were made of. The thief left it here.")
5. At the bell: hand over the sealed **CLUE 1** envelope for this squad. Dump the vinegar cup in the bucket, pour an inch of fresh. Ten seconds.

Fixes

- Measurements disagree: measure heel to toe together, once.
- Fast squad: lift a fingerprint off a cup with pencil graphite and tape.
- Kid won't touch powder: swap jobs with a ruler.

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Ruler.** Measures the footprint heel to toe, calls out the number.
2. **Second ruler.** Measures it again. Different numbers? Both measure once more, together.
3. **Chart reader.** Finds the number on the Bureau chart, announces the size, writes it in the case file.
4. **Chemist.** A spoonful of each known powder into the vinegar, one at a time. Which one erupted?
5. **Evidence tech.** Drops the EVIDENCE powder into the vinegar, announces the result, writes it in the case file.

Say "candy" until Video 1 has played. Say "squishies" after.

Every squad arrives knowing what the whole room knows. Don't get ahead of the story.

Bin

- Footprint sheet + clear sheet protector
- 5 rulers, pencils
- Shoe-size chart
- 3 labeled cups: FLOUR, POWDERED SUGAR, BAKING SODA, a plastic spoon in each
- The EVIDENCE bag: baking soda, with its own spoon
- 1 clear cup, an inch of vinegar; the vinegar bottle and a dump bucket for resets
- Rimmed tray, paper towels
- 4 CLUE 1 envelopes (one per squad)
- Backup Wanted sketch sheets

2 Ghostbuster Lab

Fizz open the evidence · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 2**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



> **SAY**
> "These ghosts are holding evidence hostage. The only thing they can't survive is vinegar. One syringe each. Bust them."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. Five ghosts in the bin, one per detective. Each gets a syringe of green vinegar.
2. Bust the ghost until it fizzes apart and the word slip appears. Sleeves up.
3. Each detective lays their own word in the line. Whoever got SEEN reads the sentence aloud: **"SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15."** Whoever got 2:15 writes it in the case file.
4. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 2** envelope (same sentence, sealed, for the file). Scoop out the residue, set five fresh ghosts.

Fixes

- Ghost won't break: more vinegar, poke it with the syringe tip.
- Kid doesn't want to touch it: they're the reader who assembles the words.
- Words out of order: "Read it like a sentence. Where does SEEN go?"

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Everyone:** one ghost, one syringe. Bust it until your word slip appears.
2. **Everyone:** lay your word in the line on the table and move it until the sentence reads right.
3. **Whoever got SEEN** reads the sentence aloud.
4. **Whoever got 2:15** writes it in the case file.
5. **Whoever got HALL** scoops the fizz into the bin at the bell.

Mess control

Tablecloth under the bin. Fizz stays in the bin. The residue is harmless but keep sleeves up and wipes within reach.

Bin

- 25 baking-soda ghosts, in muffin tins
- Pitcher of green vinegar
- 6 syringes (one spare)
- Big under-bed bin as the lab tray
- Tablecloth, paper towels, wipes
- 4 CLUE 2 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

3 The Cipher Room

Ransom note and invisible ink · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 3**



11 min | Calm station | Arrive 1:10

SAY

"The thief left a note and thinks we can't read it. Prove them wrong. Then check the paper again. Thieves always leave something behind."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. Hand the squad a ransom note and the Pigpen key. Five words, one per detective; letters go on the lines under the shapes. About 3 minutes.
2. Once 1 has read the note aloud: "Now sweep the blacklight across the whole page." (2 holds the light.)
3. The highlighter P.S. appears: **"SNAGGED SOMETHING ORANGE ON THE SHELF. WORTH IT."** 3 reads it aloud, 4 writes it in the case file.
4. Each detective writes a one-line secret message in Pigpen on a take-home card (mini key on the back) for someone at home to crack.
5. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 3** envelope. Collect the key; the used note stays with you.

Hints and fixes

- Two free hints per squad. Make them ask.
- Stuck: give them the first word.
- Fast: they write a second message for the next squad to solve.
- Stuck on a dot: "A dot means the second trip through the grid."

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **Everyone:** one word each, five words for five detectives. Write each letter on the line under its shape.
2. **1** reads the whole note aloud once every word is done.
3. **2** holds the blacklight and sweeps the page.
4. **3** reads the P.S. aloud.
5. **4** writes it in the case file. **5** keeps the key and helps anyone stuck on a dot.

Answer

Every note says the same thing: **YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT**. Five words, 18 letters.

Bin

- 4 ransom notes (A to D), P.S. already written in highlighter
- Pigpen key, printed large
- Pencils, 20 take-home message cards with mini keys (ransom-notes PDF, last page)
- 2 blacklight flashlights
- Dark box (shoebox with a hand hole) if the room can't dim
- 4 CLUE 3 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

4 The Mummy Witness

Wrap a mummy, send it to the witness box · Evidence envelope: **CLUE 4**

11 min | High energy | Arrive 1:05



SAY

"I am the witness. I saw everything. But I only speak to mummies. You have ninety seconds. Make me one."

Run it

1. Count off 1 to 5. Number 5 is the mummy; 1 to 4 each get one roll and one limb (jobs at right). Mummy stands on the start line, arms out.
2. **Ninety seconds on the stopwatch.** Wrap. Eyes and mouth stay free. Whoever finishes a limb first wraps the body. Call out the last ten seconds.
3. "Time. Mummy, the witness box is ten feet away. Only a mummy may open it. Go." The mummy hobbles over, tears free, takes **one** envelope.
4. 1 reads the statement aloud, 2 writes it in the case file. It all means "the thief loves squishies." 3 and 4 bag every scrap: "Detectives, bag the evidence."
5. Time left? Round two with a new mummy and a time to beat. Six minutes is plenty for one round; two fits if the squad is quick.
6. At the bell: hand over the **CLUE 4** envelope. New rolls out.

Fixes

- Nobody wants to be the mummy: you are. Then all five wrap, 1 and 2 arms, 3 and 4 legs, 5 the body.
- Two kids want it: the second one is round two's mummy.
- Paper tearing too fast: wrap looser. Cheap paper is the point.
- Best-wrapped and funniest hobble get a shout-out, not just fastest.

Five detectives, five jobs

Count off 1 to 5 as they arrive. New count at every station, so the jobs shuffle.

1. **5 is the mummy.** Stands still, arms out, mouth and eyes free.
2. **1 left arm, 2 right arm, 3 left leg, 4 right leg.** One roll each. Whoever finishes first wraps the body.
3. **Then:** the mummy hobbles to the box, tears free, takes one envelope.
4. **1 reads** the statement aloud. **2 writes** it in the case file.
5. **3 and 4 bag the evidence.** Every scrap in the trash bag before the bell.

What the statement means

Knew where the avocado one was, squeezed it, whispered "so satisfying," hugged the Jar like a puppy. One fact: the thief loves squishies.

Bin

- 20 rolls of the cheapest toilet paper (4 per squad, plus spares for round two)
- Trash bags, stopwatch
- Witness box with 4 sealed statements (all the same)
- Tape for the start line, 10-foot hobble course
- 4 CLUE 4 envelopes
- Backup sketch sheets

FL

Floater / Photographer

Door, badges, restocks, photos, the hidden tags

Arrive 1:00 · Whole party



Before 1:30

- Crime-scene tape on the door frame (door stays usable). LED candle at each station.
- Cauldron and the Evidence Locker (under a cloth) by the Chief's desk.
- Spare badges and 5 case files on the door table.

Timeline

1. **1:30** Door: kids wear the badge they filled in at training (1 purple, 2 black, 3 teal, 4 orange); spare badges and the squad list for anyone whose badge went missing. Each squad gets its numbered case file. Point each squad to the station with its number.
2. **1:38 to 2:28** Rotations: bathroom runs in pairs, restock stations (TP, vinegar, wipes), photos of each station (check the opt-out list first).
3. **Each bell:** dim the lights while the Detective plays the video; back up to "dim" when it ends.
4. **Rotation 3 (2:04):** hide the 20 highlighter-marked evidence tags around the room: under desks, inside books, under chairs. Nobody notices; they're busy.
5. **2:28** Deliberation: lights up. Snacks by squad if food is approved. Open the Wanted Poster table. Collect warrants into the cauldron. (The Detective handles the Chief's statement form.)
6. **2:40** Warrants read, Video 4 plays. Hand 3 blacklight flashlights to each squad. Stand by the lit hallway door during lights-out.
7. **2:48** Lights up. The Chief brings the Jar out. You run the trade: one tag, one squishy (candy layer first if there is one).
8. **2:55** Group photo with badges. Strike stations with the leads. Trash out. Tablecloths rolled and tossed.

Bin

- Spare badges (4 colors), 5 case files
- Spare TP, spare wipes, trash bags
- 20 evidence tags (highlighter-marked)
- 12 blacklight flashlights
- The EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy (goes to the Detective before 1:30)
- Camera or phone, photo opt-out list
- Squad list from the Chief

The one thing that can't slip

The 20 tags must be hidden before 2:40. If rotation 3 gets away from you, hide them during rotation 4.

You are the only adult without a station. Everyone will ask you for things.

DET

The Detective's cue card

Opening, the live beat after Video 1, the finale lines



Room parent · Trench coat, clipboard

1:30 · THE OPENING (LIGHTS OFF, 90 SECONDS MAX)

"Detectives, we have a situation. Sometime yesterday afternoon, the Party Candy Jar, the one you have been staring at for a week, disappeared from that shelf. We don't know when. Yet. The door was locked. The window was shut. Somebody on this staff knows something. We have four suspects. Three of them have recorded statements, and you'll hear from them as the investigation unfolds. The fourth, the Custodian, declined to comment. Make of that what you will. We have four pieces of evidence, and exactly one hour before the trail goes cold. Your squad has a case file. Fill it in. Clear the innocent and you'll know who did it. Chief _____ has assured me she is not a suspect. Let's begin."

1:49 · RIGHT AFTER VIDEO 1 (THE PRINCIPAL)

Let the room react for five seconds. Then: "Did... did the Principal just say squishies?" Reach into the coat. Pull out the EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy. "Recovered from under that shelf this morning. I assumed it was unrelated." Turn to the Chief. "Chief. What exactly was in that jar?" *The Chief, flustered: "Candy. ...Mostly. Candy-adjacent."* Back to the room: "Detectives. That jar was never candy. Open your case files. Cross out 'candy.' Write 'squishies.' This changes nothing about the evidence and everything about the motive. Rotate."

2:02 AND 2:15 · AFTER VIDEOS 2 AND 3

One line each, then the bell. "The Reading Specialist does not understand squishies. Noted. Rotate." / "Check their feet. Hm. Rotate."

2:28 · THE FIFTH STATEMENT

The first squad to say "everyone's crossed off" gets it said for the room: "Then your list is too short. Four clues: size 9, in the building at 2:15, wore orange, loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" Let them guess. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect." You: "Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." Pin it to the board next to the other four and read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous." "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

2:40 · WARRANTS AND THE FINAL STATEMENT

Pull each warrant from the cauldron and read it aloud: "Squad 1 accuses... the Chief." The Chief protests: "This is outrageous. I'm the Chief." You: "There is one more statement. It was recorded under protest." Play Video 4. When it ends: "Detectives, you heard her. A very special light. In one minute the lights go out for three minutes. Flashlights to the squads. Every detective finds one tag. Then we open the Jar."